SAMPLE

The Online Consultant

Package Your Expertise and Sell Advisory Services

Aiman Sterling

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

putrabooks.github.io

Contents

Introduction

Chapter 1: Defining Your Consulting Niche and Offering

Chapter 2: Creating Consulting Packages

Chapter 3: Setting Premium Rates with Confidence

Chapter 4: Finding Consulting Clients Online

Chapter 5: Running Effective Consulting Sessions

Chapter 6: Converting Sessions to Retainers and Scaling

Chapter 7: The Consulting Offer Project

Chapter 8: Building Your Consulting Brand and Authority

Chapter 9: Consulting Deliverables That Wow Clients

Chapter 10: Transitioning From Solo Consultant to Consulting Agency

Final Thoughts

Quick Start Checklist

Resources

Digital Income

This free sample contains the Introduction and Chapter 1. The complete book contains the full contents above.

Introduction

You've spent years building expertise. You know your industry inside and out. You've solved problems, navigated challenges, and developed insights that less experienced people would pay to access.

But you're earning from that expertise the wrong way — through a salary. Your knowledge is locked inside a job, and the only way to earn more is to get a promotion or switch employers.

Consulting unlocks your expertise. Instead of selling your time to one employer, you package your knowledge as advisory services and sell them to multiple clients — at premium rates. Online consulting makes this possible without travel, office space, or geographic limitations.

This book is about building an online consulting business that commands premium rates — not $50/hour freelancing, but $200-$1,000/hour advisory work.

Every business needs expertise it doesn't have in-house. A startup needs go-to-market strategy. A mid-size company needs operational optimization. A SaaS company needs pricing strategy. A local business needs digital transformation guidance.

These companies can't afford to hire a full-time executive with that expertise — but they can afford to hire a consultant for a defined project or ongoing advisory.

That's your opportunity: package your expertise as advisory services and sell them to businesses that need what you know but can't afford to hire full-time.

- Experienced professionals (5+ years in your field) who want to monetize their knowledge independently.

- Subject matter experts who are the go-to person in their company for specific topics.

- Former executives or managers who want to consult instead of returning to a full-time role.

- Specialists (marketing, finance, operations, technology, HR, legal) who want to sell advisory services online.

- Anyone with deep expertise who wants to earn premium rates for their knowledge.

- How to define your consulting niche and offering.

- How to create consulting packages.

- How to set premium rates with confidence.

- How to find consulting clients online.

- How to run effective consulting sessions.

- How to convert one-off sessions to retainers.

- How to scale consulting with products and group offers.

- A practical project: create a consulting offer with pricing and client acquisition plan.

Here's the principle: consulting is not about time — it's about outcomes.

A freelancer sells hours. A consultant sells results. The freelancer says "I'll work for you for 10 hours at $50/hour." The consultant says "I'll help you solve [specific problem] for $5,000 — regardless of how many hours it takes."

The market pays consultants more because consultants take responsibility for outcomes, not just effort. A client doesn't care how many hours you worked — they care whether their problem is solved.

This book teaches you how to position, package, and sell your expertise as outcome-based consulting — at premium rates that reflect the value you create, not the time you spend.

The consulting industry is undergoing a transformation. Three forces are reshaping how consultants find clients, deliver value, and build their practices:

Force 1: The democratization of expertise. Information is freely available. Clients can research any topic, find any framework, and access any methodology online. This means consultants can no longer charge for information alone — they must charge for application, judgment, and results.

Force 2: The rise of AI tools. AI can now do research, draft reports, and generate analysis at a level that used to require a junior consultant. This means the bar for consulting deliverables has risen — clients expect more thorough, more polished, more data-backed work. But AI also means a solo consultant can produce the output of a small team.

Force 3: The shift to specialized expertise. Generalist consultants are struggling. Clients can find generic advice online for free. They hire consultants for deep, specific expertise in their exact situation. The more specialized your niche, the more you can charge — because the fewer alternatives the client has.

These three forces create both challenge and opportunity. The challenge: generic consultants who charge for information are being commoditized. The opportunity: specialized consultants who use AI to deliver high-quality work efficiently can build highly profitable practices with lower overhead than ever before.

This book is for the consultant who wants to capitalize on the opportunity — not defend against the challenge. The consultants who adapt will thrive. The ones who don't will watch their market shrink.

Defining Your Consulting Niche and Offering

Chapter 1: Defining Your Consulting Niche and Offering

A generalist consultant competes on price. A specialist consultant competes on expertise. Your niche determines your rates, your clients, and how easy it is to find work.

In freelancing, you sell a skill (writing, design, coding). In consulting, you sell expertise — and expertise is always niche. Nobody consults on "business." They consult on "pricing strategy for SaaS companies" or "operational efficiency for manufacturing businesses."

The more specific your niche, the more you can charge — because fewer people have your specific combination of expertise, and the clients in that niche value your specialized knowledge.

Your consulting niche = Your expertise area + Your target client + The problem you solve.

Examples:

- "I help SaaS startups optimize their pricing strategy."

- "I help e-commerce businesses reduce customer acquisition costs."

- " I help healthcare companies implement digital transformation."

- "I help agencies improve their project profitability."

- "I help fintech companies navigate regulatory compliance."

What do you know more about than 95% of people in your industry? This isn't "I'm good at marketing" — it's "I know how to launch a product on Product Hunt and get 5,000 signups in 48 hours."

Expertise sources:

- Your job title and responsibilities.

- Problems you've solved repeatedly.

- Decisions you've made that drove measurable results.

- Areas where colleagues and peers seek your advice.

- Frameworks or systems you've developed.

- Industries you understand deeply.

Who needs your expertise? Be specific:

- Industry (SaaS, e-commerce, healthcare, finance, education).

- Company size (startups, small businesses, mid-market, enterprise).

- Stage (pre-launch, growth, mature, turnaround).

- Geography (if relevant — though online consulting is location- independent).

What specific problem does your expertise address? The more specific, the more valuable:

- "Pricing strategy" -> "I help SaaS companies find the optimal price point that maximizes revenue without losing customers."

- "Marketing" -> "I help B2B companies build lead generation systems that produce 50+ qualified leads per month."

- "Operations" -> "I help service businesses reduce delivery costs by 20-30% without sacrificing quality."

"I help [target client] solve [specific problem] through [your approach]."

Example: "I help seed-stage SaaS startups optimize their pricing strategy through a structured audit and recommendation process. Typical engagement: 4 weeks, $5,000-$15,000."

You assess the client's current situation and provide a report with findings and recommendations. Low time commitment, clear deliverable.

What it includes:

- Review of the client's current state (data, processes, documents).

- Identification of problems and opportunities.

- Written report with findings, recommendations, and a prioritized action plan.

- 1-hour walkthrough call to discuss findings.

Price: $1,000-$5,000.

Time: 5-15 hours.

Purpose: Entry point that proves your value. Many audits lead to larger engagements.

You work with the client over a defined period to develop and deliver a specific strategy or solution.

What it includes:

- Audit/research phase.

- Strategy development.

- Implementation plan.

- Stakeholder presentation.

- 30-60 day support during implementation.

Price: $5,000-$25,000.

Time: 20-80 hours over 4-8 weeks.

Purpose: The core of most consulting businesses. High per-project revenue.

You provide ongoing advisory support — regular calls, email access, and on-demand guidance.

What it includes:

- Weekly or bi-weekly strategy calls (60 minutes).

- Email/Slack access for questions.

- Monthly progress review.

- Quarterly strategy session.

Price: $2,000-$10,000/month.

Time: 4-8 hours/month.

Purpose: Recurring revenue and long-term client relationships.

You not only develop the strategy but also oversee or execute the implementation.

What it includes:

- Strategy development.

- Project management of implementation.

- Team coordination and vendor management.

- Regular reporting and adjustment.

- Full implementation support.

Price: $10,000-$50,000+.

Time: 40-200 hours over 2-6 months.

Purpose: The highest-ticket offering. Requires more time but commands premium rates.

- Write down your top 3 areas of expertise.

- For each, identify who would pay for this expertise and what problem it solves.

- Write a positioning statement for each: "I help [client] solve [problem] through [approach]."

- Choose the strongest combination (highest demand, highest rates, best fit with your experience).

- Design your 4 offerings: audit, strategy project, retainer, implementation.

- Set initial pricing for each offering.

Your niche and offerings are the foundation of your consulting business. The more specific and outcome-oriented, the more you can charge and the easier it is to find clients. Define your niche clearly, and every other decision — pricing, marketing, delivery — becomes easier.

Choosing a niche is a hypothesis. You need to test it before committing fully. Here's how to validate that your niche is viable.

Test 1: Demand validation

Is there real demand for your expertise in this niche?

- Search for your niche + "consultant" or "advisor" on LinkedIn. Are there others offering this service? (Competition validates demand.)

- Search for your niche + "help" or "problem" in online communities. Are people asking for help?

- Talk to 5-10 people in your target audience. Do they have the problem you solve? Would they pay for a solution?

Test 2: Pricing validation

Can people in this niche afford to pay consulting rates?

- Research the average revenue of companies in your niche

- Check what other consultants charge for similar services

- Ask potential clients what they'd expect to pay for your service

- Test with a low-cost engagement ($500-1,000) to see if clients will pay

Test 3: Access validation

Can you actually reach decision-makers in this niche?

- Can you find them on LinkedIn?

- Are they active in communities you can join?

- Do they respond to outreach?

- Can you get referrals to them?

Test 4: Expertise validation

Do you have enough expertise to deliver results?

- Can you name the top 5 challenges in this niche?

- Can you describe how to solve each one?

- Have you solved similar problems before?

- Can you point to specific examples or case studies?

If your tests show weak demand, low pricing, or poor access — pivot. Niches are not permanent commitments. You can refine, narrow, or change your niche based on market feedback.

The pivot process:

- Identify what didn't work (demand, pricing, access, or expertise)

- Adjust one variable (different audience, different problem, different geography)

- Re-run the validation tests

- Repeat until you find a niche that passes all four tests

Most successful consultants pivoted 2-3 times before finding their ideal niche. Each pivot is a learning experience — not a failure.

Once you've validated your niche, write your positioning statement:

"I help [specific audience] solve [specific problem] so they can [specific outcome]. Unlike [alternatives], I [unique difference]."

Examples:

- "I help SaaS startups optimize their customer onboarding process so they can

increase trial-to-paid conversion by 20%+. Unlike general growth consultants, I've personally built onboarding systems for 15+ SaaS companies."

- "I help e-commerce brands implement AI-powered customer service so they can reduce response time by 80% and cut support costs by 50%. Unlike tech consultants, I focus specifically on the customer service workflow — not the technology stack."

Your positioning statement should pass the "so what?" test. If someone asks "so what?" after hearing it, your statement is too vague. Make it specific enough that the response is "tell me more" — not "so what?"

Creating Consulting Packages

End of free sample. The full book is available at putrabooks.github.io